AIBuilder Marketplace

The Honest SaaS Buyer's Handbook

Every pricing trick, defined and counted. The statistics vendors would rather you didn't have. The 186 genuinely free tools. And the checklist that keeps your software bill honest.

Edition: October 2026 · built from 540 hand-researched pricing dossiers · no invented numbers
Free forever at https://aibuildermarketplace.com/handbook/ — subscribers get every new edition automatically.

1 · The six pricing tricks — and how often they occur

Counted across 540 hand-researched dossiers; every count is backed by an evidence sentence in the public dataset (CC BY 4.0).

Usage-based (metered) pricing **250 van 540 tools**

Credits, message counts, overage fees or percentage cuts on top of the plan. Fair when the meter is public; dangerous when it's buried. Always model your real volume before trusting the sticker.

Per-seat pricing **132 van 540 tools**

The bill scales with every user you add — a quiet tax on growth. Ask: does value really scale with headcount here? Flat-fee alternatives exist in most categories.

Paid add-ons **153 van 540 tools**

Key features sold separately: payroll on top of bookkeeping, verification on top of email. Price the bundle you actually need, never the base plan.

Annual lock-in **121 van 540 tools**

The advertised price only exists with a yearly commitment. You carry the risk: a year paid before you know if the tool sticks. Compute the monthly-billing premium before deciding.

Quote-only (hidden) pricing **34 van 540 tools**

No public price list — a sales call required. Enables per-customer pricing and makes comparison impossible. Budget serious evaluation time, and never enter that call without an anchor.

Renewal jump **13 van 540 tools**

The intro price is not the renewal price — standing practice in hosting and security. The only number that matters is year two. Put the renewal date in your calendar with a cancel window.

2 · The numbers (October 2026)

Tools with ≥1 documented cost caveat	**79%**
Meters usage on top of the subscription	**46%**
Charges per seat	**24%**
Sells key features as paid add-ons	**28%**
Requires annual commitment for the advertised price	**22%**
Publishes no usable price at all	**6%**
Has a genuinely free tier	**34%**

> Only **21%** of tools have a sticker price that is also the whole story. Full methodology & live data: https://aibuildermarketplace.com/research/

3 · The honest buyer's checklist

1. Find the real price: your volume, your seat count, the add-ons you need — not the sticker.
2. Check the meter: what happens at 2× your current usage? At 10×?
3. Read the renewal terms before the intro price seduces you. Year two is the real price.
4. Genuinely free tier? Test the actual workflow on it before paying anything.
5. Cancel-test: how many clicks to leave? If you can't find out, that's your answer.
6. One tool per job: name the job each subscription owns. Two tools, one job = one candidate to kill.
7. Calendar every renewal date with a 2-week cancel window (our free Renewal Radar generates the reminders).
8. Verify claims against evidence — ours or anyone's. A review without receipts is an ad.

> **The cancel-first test:** unsure about a subscription? Cancel it. Re-subscribe if you genuinely miss it within a month. Most people never do — that silence is the honest verdict.

4 · The 186 genuinely free tools

Real free tiers you can run on indefinitely — not trials in a costume. Live links & dossiers: https://aibuildermarketplace.com/atlas/ (filter: Free tier).

Analytics

Amplitude

Business Operations

Assembly

Communication & Voice

CometChat, CrankWheel, Fireflies.ai, Freshchat, ZenZap

Content & Media

ElevenLabs

Customer Support

AskNest, Cloze, Help Scout, HelpCenter, NeuroAds, StoreFAQ, Tidio

Design & Content

AhaSlides, Clonable, LumenCart, Modelize, Piktochart, Pixlr, Retouch4me, Section Library, Wegic

Developer Tools

BrowserAct, DigitalOcean, UptimeRobot

E-commerce

Bold Memberships, Bot It AI, Brandye, Code Bulk Discounts, Consentmo, Easy Bundles, EcomXray, Essent Preorder Back in Stock, Essential Announcement Bar, Essential Countdown Timer Bar, Essential Free Shipping Bar, Essential Trust Badges, Essential Upsell & Cross Sell, Feedyio, Kite, Kiwi Sizing, Loyalino, Nexis CRO, Pricefy, Rapid Search, Scrolly, Securify, Seel, Smarty Discounts, Timesact Preorder, Track123, Vendoo, Vify Order Printer, VyReel, Zendrop

Financial Operations

Aspire, Melio, Zeffy, Zenind

Growth & Revenue

AISQ, AWeber, Apollo, Attribuly, Beefree, Beehiiv, Bitscale, Brevo, Capsule, Clay, Crazy Egg, Essential Loyalty, Gelato, Hello Bar, Iconosquare, Kit, Leadfeeder, ManyChat, Notify Me, Optizen, Outgrow, Parallel AI, Poptin, Post Purchase Upsell Hero, Printify, Pumper Bundles, PushOwl, Rank Math, Restream, Seamless.ai, Selleasy, Stampezee, Streak, Success.co, SurveySparrow, Upsell & Cross Sell - AW, Upsell.com, UserTrail, VidPal

HR & People

Jibble, Leavo, TestGorilla

IT & Productivity

Blinq, Bright Data, Browse.ai, Claude, Consensus, Devs.ai, Emergent, ExpertEx, Getscreen, Glide, Lovable, MindStudio, NordPass, Proton, Proton Drive, QuickSigner, SMTP2GO, Softr, WebCatalog

Marketing

AutoWrite, Bread & Butter, Cloro, Dondy, Meeri, Nextify.ai, PagePulse, Pippit, SEO Space, Sender, Storista, involve.me

Operations & Workflow

Alohi, Bokun, BookX, Breezy HR, ClickUp, Connecteam, Databox, Descript, FlexiQuiz, Gamma, Goflow, Hive, Katana MRP, Miro, Momence, Murf, Pangram, Prezi, QuillBot, Reclaim.ai, Sendcloud, ServiceM8, Shippo, SimplyBook.me, SurveyMonkey, Survicate, Synthesia, Team Pulse, Todoist, Toggl, Wrike, ZenBusiness

Productivity

TextExpander, xTiles

SEO & Marketing

AgentNest, Postscript, SEOKart, SEOmatic, StoreSEO, Tapita AI SEO Blog Builder, Tapita SEO Optimizer

Sales & CRM

Claap, EngageBay, HubSpot, Lusha, ReachStream, Spiky.ai, Storylane

Security

WPLP, iubenda

Video & Audio

Wistia

Website Builders

Weblium

5 · The Honest Software Awards 2026

No entry, no fees, no pay-to-play — winners drawn from the research corpus, each with its evidence:

Aisdr, Beautiful Ai, Clickup, Contractor Foreman, Flocksy, Gamma, Jubilee, Kit, Landingi, Printify, Rank Math, Reclaim Ai, Tax1099, Toggl

Categories & receipts: https://aibuildermarketplace.com/awards/

6 · Keep it honest, automatically

Everything in this handbook updates itself on the site: the Atlas (dossiers), Price Watch (documented hikes with archived receipts), the statistics, and Stack X-Ray (audit what you already pay — in your browser).

> **One honest email, only when there is something worth sending** — new dossiers, price-hike alerts and each new handbook edition: https://aibuildermarketplace.com (newsletter box on every page).

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